

University of Oxford — Computer Science and Philosophy (BA / MCompPhil)

Program Dossier · The Admission Book · Fall 2027 Entry · Research date: August 16, 2026

Oxford’s **Computer Science and Philosophy** degree is the closest thing either ancient university offers to this book’s central thesis — study minds, machines, and the reasoning that connects them inside one coherent course. Year 1 pairs algorithms and probability with a philosophy paper literally titled “*Alan Turing on computability and intelligence*”; by Year 3 the split between machine learning and philosophy of mind can run 25–75 in either direction. Three facts govern the decision: an applicant may apply to **Oxford or Cambridge, not both, in the same year**; the required **TMUA admissions test must be booked by September 28, 2026** — before the **October 15** UCAS deadline; and Oxford offers **no need-based aid to US undergraduates** — the course is financed by family funds and US federal loans. US applicants succeeded at **about 6.5%** over 2022–24.

1. The university at a glance

Fact	Detail	Source
Location / type	Oxford, England; collegiate public research university; teaching built on the weekly tutorial	Oxford — personalised learning
Identity line	<i>Dominus illuminatio mea</i> — “The Lord is my light”	Motto
Overall admit rate	~ 14.1% (2024 cycle: 23,061 applied, 3,245 admitted)	Admissions statistics
US applicant success	~ 6.5% (2,629 applications, 172 admitted, 2022–24)	Same statistics pages
Course admit rate	CS & Philosophy: 10% , average intake 14 (3-yr avg 2023–25)	Course page
US academic benchmark	~4 AP 5s incl. Calculus BC + maths/science, or 3 AP 5s + SAT ≥1470 / ACT ≥32 (CS-family courses)	CS dept offers
Application	UCAS, October 15, 2026, 6pm UK · decisions January 12, 2027	2027-entry guide
Admissions test	TMUA (both papers) — book July 20 – Sep 28, 2026 ; sit Oct 12–16, 2026	Admissions tests
Fees (overseas, 2026/27)	Course fee £62,820/yr + living £12,600–18,900 ; ~3 years (BA) or 4 (MCompPhil)	Course fees · Living costs

2. The big picture — what kind of place this is

Oxford’s undergraduate education runs through the **tutorial**: one to three students, one expert, every week, defending prepared work out loud. Admission is built to find people who will thrive in that room, and the university says so with unusual bluntness — “Tutors at Oxford are only interested in your academic ability and potential,” and extracurricular activities count “only in so far as they demonstrate the selection criteria for your course.” This is the inverse of US holistic admissions: no activities résumé, no leadership narrative, no community-impact essay. One subject, argued deeply, is the whole game.

Two structural rules follow. First, applicants choose **one course before applying** and are examined against it — there is no undeclared year. Second, the application runs on the UK calendar: UCAS closes **October 15, 2026 at 6pm UK time**, the admissions test is sat in mid-October, shortlisted candidates interview **online in December**, and every decision lands on **January 12, 2027** — before most US regular decisions are even read.

3. The program — Computer Science and Philosophy

The degree is jointly owned by the Department of Computer Science and the Faculty of Philosophy, and it is *designed* around the question this book’s applicant profile keeps asking: what is intelligence, in machines and in minds, and how should reasoning about it work?

- **Year 1.** Computer science: functional programming, imperative programming, algorithm design, discrete mathematics, probability. Philosophy: introduction to logic, general philosophy, and “**Alan Turing on computability and intelligence**” — the foundations of machine intelligence as a first-year paper.
- **Year 2.** Core CS (~25%): models of computation, algorithms, a group design practical. CS options (~25%): **artificial intelligence**, compilers, databases, logic and proof. Philosophy (~50%): **ethics**, knowledge and reality, **philosophy of mind**, philosophy of science.
- **Year 3.** The split is elective, 25–75 either way. CS side: **machine learning**, computer-aided formal verification, quantum information. Philosophy side: **philosophy of cognitive science**, philosophical logic, and an optional **philosophy thesis**.
- **Year 4 (optional MCompPhil).** Advanced options (computer vision, geometric deep learning) plus advanced philosophy and a thesis. All students apply for the four-year course and decide in Year 3 whether to take the fourth year.

The **Institute for Ethics in AI** lives inside the same Philosophy Faculty that teaches half this degree — its lunchtime seminars, the Philosophy, Law & Politics Colloquium, and annual lectures are open events an undergraduate can simply walk into.

4. How the pieces fit together

The profile this book is built around wants computation *and* the study of minds *and* the institutions that govern intelligent systems — usually assembled from three departments. Here it is one course: the technical spine is real (TMUA-gated, algorithms-first), the philosophy half carries ethics, mind, and cognitive science, and the eventual application domain — law — is served the standard UK way: any strong degree feeds a US JD or a UK law conversion afterward. The honest gap: there is no named law/policy paper inside the course; the governance thread is built from ethics papers, the thesis option, and the Institute’s orbit.

5. An illustrative path

Year	Computation	Philosophy	Outside the degree
1	Algorithms, probability, functional programming	Logic; the Turing paper	Orchestra auditions (week 0); college music award
2	AI option; group design practical	Ethics; philosophy of mind	Institute for Ethics in AI seminars
3	Machine learning	Philosophy of cognitive science; thesis	Thesis doubling as portfolio for law-school applications
4 (opt.)	Computer vision / deep learning	Advanced options + thesis	JD applications or UK conversion

6. Beyond the classroom — the violin at Oxford

Admission ignores performance; life does not. The **Oxford University Orchestra** and **Philharmonia** audition at the start of each term (a 3–4 minute unaccompanied solo plus sight-reading, open to any subject). More than a dozen colleges offer **instrumental awards and exhibitions to students of any degree** — Merton (£300, Grade 8+ standard), New College (£300, recital-based), St John's (£120/term of lessons + £400), Trinity, LMH, Worcester among them — typically auditioned in the first weeks of Michaelmas term. Choosing a college with a strong music society and instrumental award is the single best lever for a serious violinist here.

7. Access, feasibility, and honest risks

- **One Oxbridge slot.** Oxford's own 2027-entry guide: "you can't apply to Oxford and Cambridge in the same year." This dossier and the Cambridge dossier describe mutually exclusive applications.
- **The test comes first.** TMUA booking closes **September 28, 2026 (6pm UK)**; the test is sat **October 12–16**. Registration is the real application deadline.
- **Money.** Overseas course fee £62,820 (2026/27) plus £12,600–18,900 living: roughly **\$96–104k per year**, with **no Oxford need-based aid for US undergraduates** (Crankstart and Oxford Bursaries are home-status only; Reach Oxford excludes US nationals). US federal Direct/PLUS loans are usable. The 3-year BA partially offsets the sticker.
- **Mathematics culture.** 96% of recent CS-family offer-holders took Further Maths; the department's US benchmark names **Calculus BC** — an applicant holding Calculus AB should query the department before applying.
- **The odds.** 10% course-wide, ~6.5% for US applicants university-wide, intake of 14. This is a reach on any list.

8. Applying — logistics for Fall 2027

Step	Date (2027 entry)	Detail
TMUA booking	by Sep 28, 2026, 6pm UK	Via UAT-UK / Pearson; window opened July 20
UCAS application	by Oct 15, 2026, 6pm UK	Course choice, college choice (or open), academic reference; self-report scores — no transcripts at this stage

Step	Date (2027 entry)	Detail
Personal statement	with UCAS	New 3-question format, 4,000 characters total: why this course; how studies prepared you; what else outside education
TMUA sitting	Oct 12-16, 2026	Results Nov 16
Interviews	December 2026	Online via Microsoft Teams; tutorial-style
Decision	January 12, 2027	Via UCAS; conditional offers possible on May 2027 APs

9. Sources

Oxford 2027-entry application guide · admissions-tests page (2027 changes: TMUA/TARA via UAT-UK) · undergraduate admissions statistics · Computer Science & Philosophy course page · CS department US offer conditions · fees, living-costs, financial-support and US-loans pages · Institute for Ethics in AI · Oxford music pages, college instrumental-awards list, OUO audition page · UCAS personal-statement format pages. All retrieved August 16, 2026; re-verify time-sensitive dates on official pages — 2027/28 fee figures publish after this dossier’s research date.